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THEATRE ARTS

SCRIPTWRITING

Structure: Beats, Objectives and Scene Construction

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

How a scene is built from beats and objectives, how acts are built from scenes, and why the well-made play still teaches more about construction than any screenwriting formula.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- beats
- objectives
- obstacles
- act structure
- the well-made play

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A beat is a change, not a pause

A beat is the smallest unit of dramatic action: a character tries something, meets resistance, and changes tactic. A page of dialogue in which nobody changes tactic is one beat, however many speeches it contains. When actors say a scene "has no beats", they mean it has no changes.

Mark the beats in your draft by writing, in the margin, what each character is doing to the other: persuading, testing, punishing, begging, lying. If two consecutive beats use the same verb, one of them is probably redundant.

Objectives and obstacles

Give every character in a scene an objective that can be played: "to make her admit she knew" is playable; "to express sadness" is not. Then give the other character an obstacle that is not merely stubbornness. The strongest obstacle is a legitimate need that conflicts with the first, so that the audience can see both sides and cannot relax.

Scenes and acts

A scene ends when the balance of power or knowledge changes. An act ends when the whole situation does. A play with five scenes in which the same two people argue five times has one scene, repeated; a play with two scenes in which the second is changed by the first has structure.

The five-act and three-act patterns are not laws, but they encode a discovery: an audience needs a period of complication before a climax is satisfying, and needs the climax to produce consequences. If your draft has a strong ending and a slow middle, the fault is usually that the middle has no decision in it.

The well-made play, for and against

Scribe and Sardou built plays from a secret, a delayed confrontation and a scène à faire - the scene the audience has been promised and has come to see. Modern playwrights often laugh at the machinery and use it anyway, because it works: the audience must know what is at stake and must be made to wait.

Use the machinery consciously. If your play withholds information, decide whether the withholding is a character's choice or the author's convenience. Convenience is what makes an audience feel manipulated.

Rewriting: the second draft

The second draft is not the first draft with better sentences. It is a structural pass made after the play has been read aloud. Work through it in this order: the story (does every scene change the situation?), the characters (does every character want something in every scene they are in?), the scenes (does each begin late and end early?), the dialogue (can any speech be cut in half?), and only then the language.

Keep a "cut file" rather than deleting. Lines you love and cannot justify go into the file, and sometimes they come back in another play. The discipline is to remove them from this one.

Read the draft again for the character who speaks least. In most student plays the quiet character is the playwright's conscience and has nothing to do. Give them a want, an obstruction and one scene where they win something, and the play will gain a dimension it did not have.

The scene that will not work

When a scene refuses to work, the fault is almost never the dialogue. Check three things in order: does the scene have a decision in it, does the character who wants something have the power to get it, and does the scene start too early? Nine times out of ten the answer is the third, and the fix is to cut the first half-page.

If it still will not work, the scene may be doing a job that belongs to another scene. Move the information into the scene where it costs something, and delete this one. A play is not a set of scenes that each do one thing; it is a set of scenes that each do several things at once.

Exercises

1. Take a published scene and write the beat sheet: verb, verb, verb, one per change. Then do the same for your own scene and compare the number of changes.
2. Rewrite a scene in which your characters state their feelings, so that neither ever names what they feel and both still get what they want or fail to.
3. Outline a three-act play in twelve sentences: four per act, each a decision and its consequence.

Where to read more

William Archer, Play-Making (1912)

George Pierce Baker, Dramatic Technique (1919)

Lajos Egri, The Art of Dramatic Writing (1946)

David Howard and Edward Mabley, The Tools of Screenwriting (1993)

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